

Ambiguity Court Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	ambiguity-court

Big idea: Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Ambiguity Court Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Ambiguity Court Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Ambiguity Court Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Ambiguity Court Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Ambiguity Court Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Ambiguity Court Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How much meaning is in words and how much is in context?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room.
- Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Activity Steps

1. Give groups an ambiguous sentence with no context.
2. Students list as many possible meanings as they can.
3. Add context cards one at a time and ask which meanings become stronger or weaker.
4. Groups defend one interpretation and challenge another.
5. Debrief how context, intention, and audience shape linguistic knowledge.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How much meaning is in the words and how much is supplied by context?
- When is an interpretation justified rather than merely possible?
- Can ambiguity be useful for knowledge?

Knowledge Questions

- How much meaning is in words and how much is in context?
- What makes an interpretation justified?
- Can ambiguous language produce knowledge?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with an ambiguous sentence or image put on trial for its most defensible interpretation. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...